

Q: So, does that mean you get sufficient open source talent from India?

I would not say what we get is sufficient. I think there is still more work to do. More training and awareness is required for open source to spread to many more colleges. Education is a really vast sector. While we (IBM) hire from a relatively small number of colleges and LTC gets very good recruits from colleges where we see good Linux and open source usage, I think the awareness and open source development skills need to spread to many more colleges in order to cater to the needs of the industry. This will help many companies to recruit more people with open source skills. So, while we are happy with the trends we are seeing, I think there is more to do in terms of spreading awareness and there are a lot of organisations actually making an effort in that direction right now.

There are free and open source software enthusiast groups that organise a lot of awareness sessions and training all around the country. All these initiatives are usually targeted to some of the lesser known universities. We have seen these events being very well attended and welcomed by the academia. I think there is a lot more to be done in that direction but the trends are good as far as we have seen within the academia, at the moment.

**Q: What level of improvements are you looking for for Linux and open source to become the norm in the education sector?**

I think we have to look at it from two perspectives. Some of the top tier colleges, which have strong academic research programs, have done fairly well in the use of Linux and open source technologies and in creating awareness around them too. They are well on track with respect to that. The real challenge is seen when it comes to open source adoption in large number of other colleges where resources are scarce and also the skills require training. Unfortunately, the knowledge and skills to impart training are also not as prevalent or not available in the large numbers that they are required. I think that is the real challenge—how do we cater to thousands of engineering colleges, some of which are in rural areas, across different parts of the country. And how do we ensure this training is in sync with the latest open source technologies. Remote institutions could also have logistic challenges in terms of the unavailability of really good Internet connections, which is very essential for any kind of open source project development. There needs to be a focus on addressing these challenges to spread the word about open source technology.

Q: Do you think there is an increase in the demand for open source talent? If yes, what are the factors driving this demand?

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in services and in other customer-facing roles. This is also being driven by the adoption of Linux and open source in enterprises. Over the last decade, the use of open source in enterprises has gone up very significantly. I think some of the recent studies show that by 2015, a fairly substantial portion—probably in the range of 80 per cent or higher—of commercial software will have some open source technology embedded in it. This projection highlights the growth of open source technology, in general. With open source becoming that prevalent, it is natural that the demand for skilled professionals who know how open source works and how to contribute back to the community is only going to go up.

In the Indian context, there are also other factors like the developments in the mobile space, which have also resulted in more demand for open source professionals, especially in the light of the development of Linux and Android.

Q: Are your clients open to adopting open source technology?

Yes, in fact, we see a lot of growth in the adoption of open source technology amongst our clients. This includes both SMEs and high-end enterprises. Most of our verticals use open source technology in one way or the other. So, all our clients from the various verticals of IBM are obviously using open source technology in one way or the other.

We also see an increase in the adoption of open source technology in the government sector. For various policy reasons, governments are more open towards open source and Linux. It provides the government and public sector organisations a significant amount of control and transparency. According to us, that is a good trend and we have responded to it by increasingly aligning our services and products to open source, which is why IBM has all of its product lines capable of running Linux.

Q: What is IBM's plan with respect to open source technologies in this FY?

We will continue to grow our business with respect to open source technologies. In order to do that, we will continue to invest in open source technology projects as this is where the future lies. 